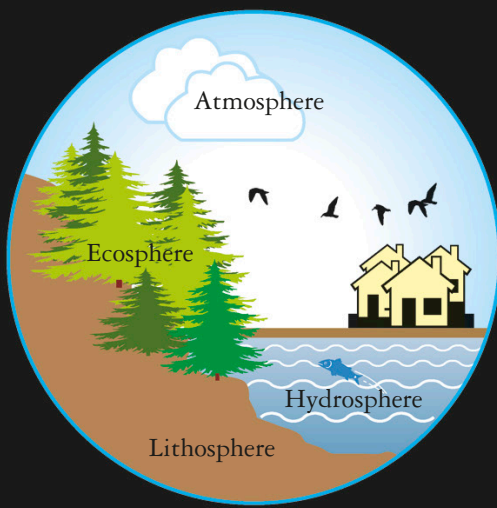




THE BIOSPHERE

Scientists call the living world the biosphere. It extends from the upper reaches of the atmosphere to the deepest trenches in the ocean and far below the surface of the land. The biosphere is where all the other “spheres”—the atmosphere (air), the hydrosphere (water), the lithosphere (land), and the ecosphere (living things), meet and interact with each other.

BIODIVERSITY

We call the variety of plants, animals, and microorganisms in an area its biodiversity. If an area has good physical conditions, such as in the tropics, then it will have a high diversity of animals and plants because it has plenty of resources to support the growth of living things. Areas with poorer conditions have fewer plant species and a limited range of animals.



Teeming with life

Some places are extremely rich in species and are known as hotspots. Many of the plants and animals in a hotspot are found only in that area. Hotspots are valuable because the wide variety of species makes them a potential source of new medicines, crops, and even ideas for technology. The downside is that such a large number of species makes these regions attractive to humans and many are now under threat from loss of habitat and overuse of their resources. Parts of the ocean also have hotspots, which makes them popular fishing grounds.

